



Thérèse of Lisieux: The Girl Who Took the Elevator

WisdomForge Booklet — Ages 5–10

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About This Book

A long time ago in France, there lived a girl named Thérèse Martin. She was small. She was not a queen. She was not a soldier. She lived most of her grown-up years behind the walls of a quiet house of prayer called Carmel, in a town named Lisieux.

People later called her the Little Flower. That name can sound like a sticker. This booklet is not a sticker book. Thérèse loved God. She loved Jesus. She loved small daily work done with love. She also got very sick, and for a long time she could not *feel* God near her. She still chose to trust.

You will meet her as a child who lost her mother, as a teenager who spoke to a pope, as a nun who smiled at someone she found hard, as a sick woman who told the truth about darkness, and as a hidden person who wanted to be love in the heart of the Church. The same girl. Six doors.

Carmel is not a castle. It is a small monastery. The nuns stay inside on purpose so they can pray and work without running from town to town. Thérèse entered at fifteen and died there at twenty-four. Nine years is not a long life. It was long enough to write pages people still argue with.

These six stories use words she really wrote, or words other people wrote down about her. A grown-up can help with the hard parts. If a chapter talks about sickness or a sad empty feeling, read it with someone. The questions at the end of each chapter are not tests. They are doors.

How to use the booklet: read a chapter aloud if you like. Stop at Words to Remember. Say the plain English line. Try one activity, not all three. Carry the grown-up question to supper. You do not have to finish in one sitting. Thérèse did not finish holiness in one sitting either.

Chapter 1: The Girl Who Spoke to the Pope

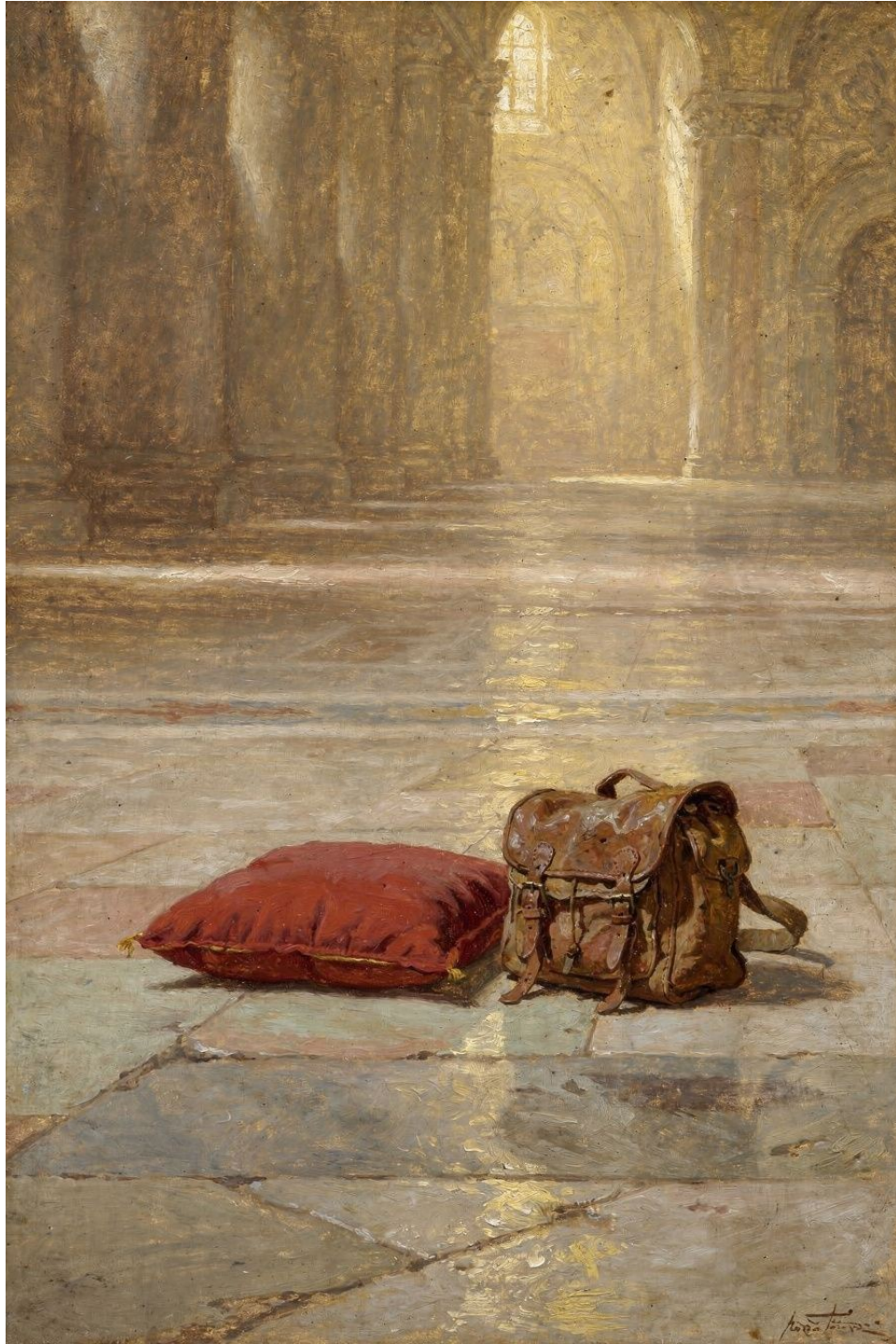


Illustration for Chapter 1

Thérèse was born on a winter day, January 2, 1873, in a town called Alençon. Her father, Louis, made watches and jewelry. Her mother, Zélie, made lace and ran a small business. They had already lost children. They loved the ones who lived with a kind of careful love, the way you hold a cup that has already been dropped once.

When Thérèse was four, her mother died of cancer. Four is young to lose a mother. The family moved to Lisieux, to a house called Les Buissonnets, to be near relatives. Pauline, an older sister, became a second mother. Then Pauline went into Carmel, the house of prayer. Thérèse felt the loss again, like a door shutting twice. She was a bright, sensitive student. Feelings sat close to the skin.

She wanted to go into Carmel too, even though she was still a child. The usual age was older — twenty-one in the old custom, later sixteen, still not fourteen. In November 1887 she traveled to Rome with her father and her sister Céline. They went through Paris, Milan, Venice, Bologna, Loreto. Churches. Crowds. Stone. Thérèse had a plan.

On November 20 they knelt before Pope Leo XIII. Pilgrims were supposed to kiss his slipper and keep quiet. Thérèse did not keep quiet. She said, "Holy Father, in honor of your jubilee, permit me to enter Carmel at the age of fifteen."

The Pope did not say yes the way she wanted. He said, "Well, my child, you will enter if it is God's will." Guards moved her along. She cried. She had to be helped away.

She did not stop. She asked the bishop of Bayeux. She asked the prioress, Mother Marie de Gonzaga. On April 9, 1888, she entered. She was fifteen. Her father was already growing frail in his mind. Leaving him cost something. Trust is not the same as it being easy. The Little Way begins here, not later: a child who asks, hears a maybe, and keeps walking.

Words to Remember

"Holy Father, in honor of your jubilee, permit me to enter Carmel at the age of fifteen."

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— Thérèse, speaking to Pope Leo XIII, November 20, 1887 (she later told the story in
Story of a Soul, Manuscript A)

Plain English: She asked a very big person a very big question, even though the rule was "don't talk."

"Well, my child, you will enter if it is God's will."

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— Pope Leo XIII, same audience

Plain English: The Pope did not slam the door. He also did not open it for her. She still had work to do at home.

Big Idea

Being little does not mean being silent when you believe God is calling you. Thérèse asked. She heard "if it is God's will." Then she kept walking the ordinary path until the door opened.

Try This

1. Draw two pictures: Thérèse kneeling and speaking, then Thérèse walking home still hoping. Under each picture write one true sentence. 2. Practice asking one clear question at home: "May I...?" Use a real request, not a pretend one. 3. With a grown-up, find Lisieux on a map of France. Put a finger on Rome too. Trace the trip.

Ask a Grown-Up

When is it right to speak up, and when is it right to wait? How do you tell?

Chapter 2: The Elevator, Not the Stairs

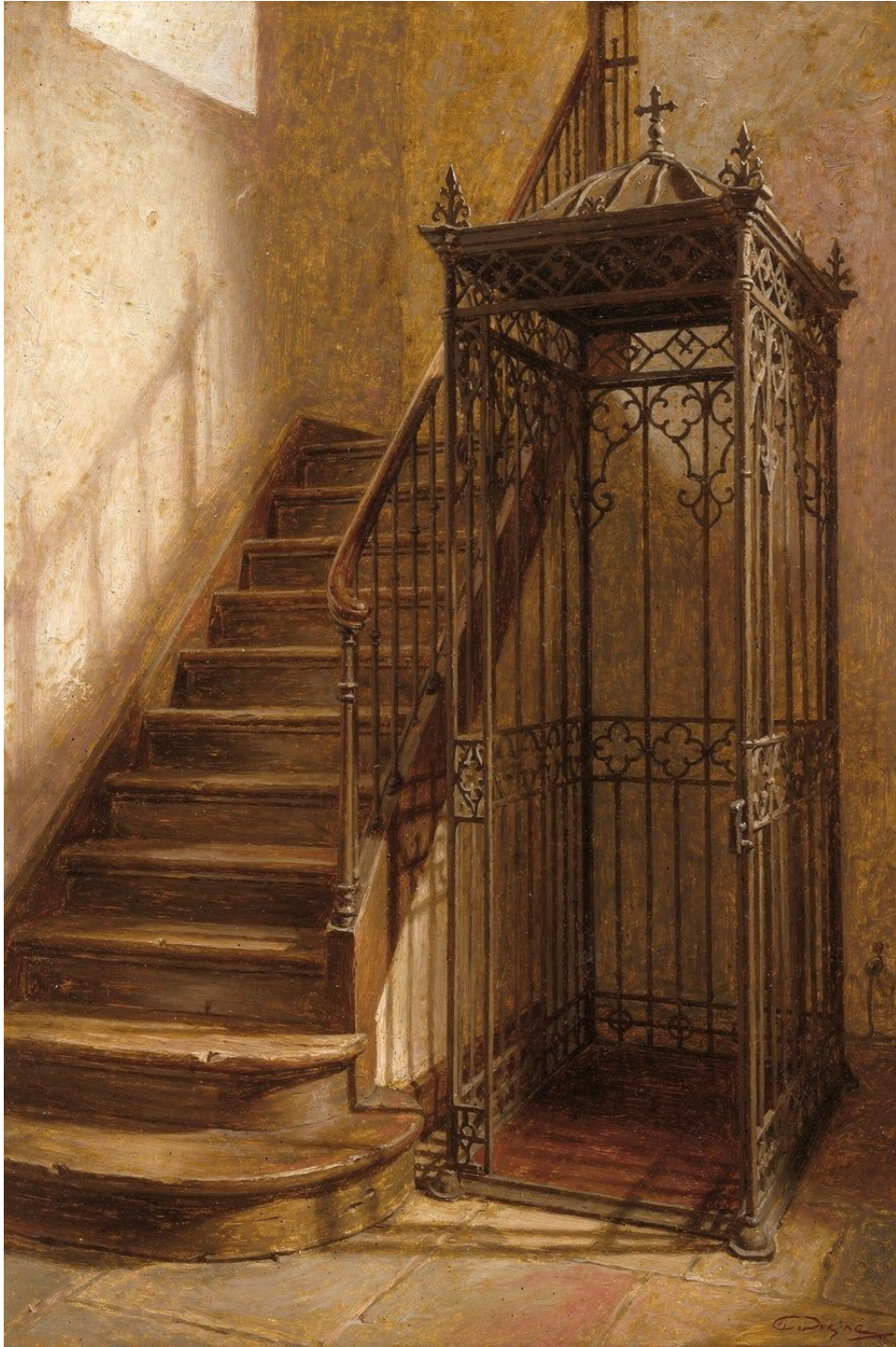


Illustration for Chapter 2

Inside Carmel, Thérèse was not famous. The house had been there since 1838. There were about twenty-five nuns. They rose early, chanted psalms, kept long silences, ate simple food, did laundry and garden work. They did not go to parties. Most of them were ordinary

French women. Thérèse was conscientious and pleasant. Nobody hung a sign that said "future teacher of the Church."

She wanted to be holy, but the old books talked about climbing a long stairway of perfection. Saints who had visions. Saints who did hard fasts. Saints who seemed tall. Teresa of Avila wrote about mansions of the soul. John of the Cross wrote about a dark climb. Those books are good books. Thérèse still felt too small for those stairs.

She looked in the Bible. She found words about little ones coming to God. Then she wrote an image that people still remember. She said she was too little to climb the rough stairway. The elevator that would lift her was the arms of Jesus. She did not need to grow up first. She needed to stay little, even become smaller.

An elevator is not laziness. A child in an elevator still wants to go up. The child still asks. The lifting is done by someone stronger. If the child pretends to be the engine, the picture breaks.

This is the Little Way. You do not earn God's love like a prize at a fair. You bring what you actually are, including the parts that are not impressive, and you trust Love to come down. The nuns around her were still washing dishes. That is where the picture had to work, or it was only a pretty sentence.

Words to Remember

"I am too little to climb the rough stairway of perfection. So I searched the Scriptures for a hint of the way, and I read: 'Whoever is a little one, let him come to me.' ... The elevator which must raise me to heaven is Your arms, O Jesus, and for that I have no need to grow up. On the contrary, I must remain little and become even smaller."

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— Thérèse, **Story of a Soul**, Manuscript B

Plain English: She could not make herself tall enough. She asked to be carried.

"It is to recognize our nothingness, to expect everything from God as a little child expects everything from its father... to be disquieted about nothing, and not to be set on gaining our living."

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— Thérèse, *on the Little Way*

Plain English: A child does not pretend to be the parent. A child trusts, and still asks for food.

Big Idea

The Little Way is not a baby version of the real spiritual life. It is a different picture of how love works: God comes down. You do not have to finish the stairs first.

Try This

1. Build a paper elevator and a paper staircase. Put a small paper person in the elevator. Tell someone why Thérèse liked that picture. 2. Do one small chore today (a dish, a shoe, a toy) as if love is watching. No speech. Just the chore. 3. When you feel too little for a job, say out loud: "I can still ask for help." Then ask.

Ask a Grown-Up

When have you needed help you could not earn? How did it feel to receive it?

Chapter 3: The Smile She Did Not Feel



Illustration for Chapter 3

Carmel was small. You cannot hide from people in a small house. The nuns did not leave. Visitors spoke through a grille. Winter was cold. Choir was long. One sister, Thérèse wrote, had "the unhappy faculty of displeasing me in everything." The sister was not a villain in a

story. She just rubbed Thérèse the wrong way. Voice. Walk. Look. Every meeting felt like a pebble in a shoe.

Thérèse could not move to another town. Enclosure means you stay. That sounds harsh. For her it was also the point: the same faces, the same psalms, the same work, until love had nowhere to hide.

So she practiced. She prayed for the sister. That was not enough for her. She also gave a sweet smile whenever they met. The smile was not a fake "I like you" sticker. It was a choice. Love, for Thérèse, was often a choice before it was a feeling. Feelings came and went. The hallway came every day.

She also cleaned, worked in the sacristy, painted, wrote little poems for feast days, and helped the sick. She wanted to do the little things in a spirit of love. She did not think the little things slipped past God. Teresa of Avila talked about high rooms of the soul. Thérèse talked about the dining room. Both were Carmelites. This booklet stays with the dining room because that is where most of us live.

If you only remember roses and a pretty statue, you miss this chapter. The Little Way happens at the table and in the hallway.

Words to Remember

"I was not content with praying earnestly for this poor Sister, but I took care to give her a sweet smile whenever I met her."

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— Thérèse, **Story of a Soul**, Manuscript A

Plain English: Prayer and a real smile. Both. On purpose.

"I know that I am not capable of doing great things. But I cannot believe that the little things escape the attention of God. I want to do all the little things in a spirit of love."

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— Thérèse, **Story of a Soul**, Manuscript A

Plain English: Small work still counts if it is love, not show.

Big Idea

You do not practice love only with people you already like. Sometimes the practice is the person you cannot avoid.

Try This

1. This week, give one kind act to someone who is not your favorite person. A smile, a turned-over chair, a quiet "your turn." Do not announce it. 2. Make a list of five "little things" in your house. Circle one. Do it today without being asked. 3. Draw the Carmel hallway: two doors, one smile. No mean faces. The point is the choice, not a cartoon enemy.

Ask a Grown-Up

Who is hard to be kind to, and what is a small kind thing that is still honest?

Chapter 4: When Prayer Feels Like Nothing

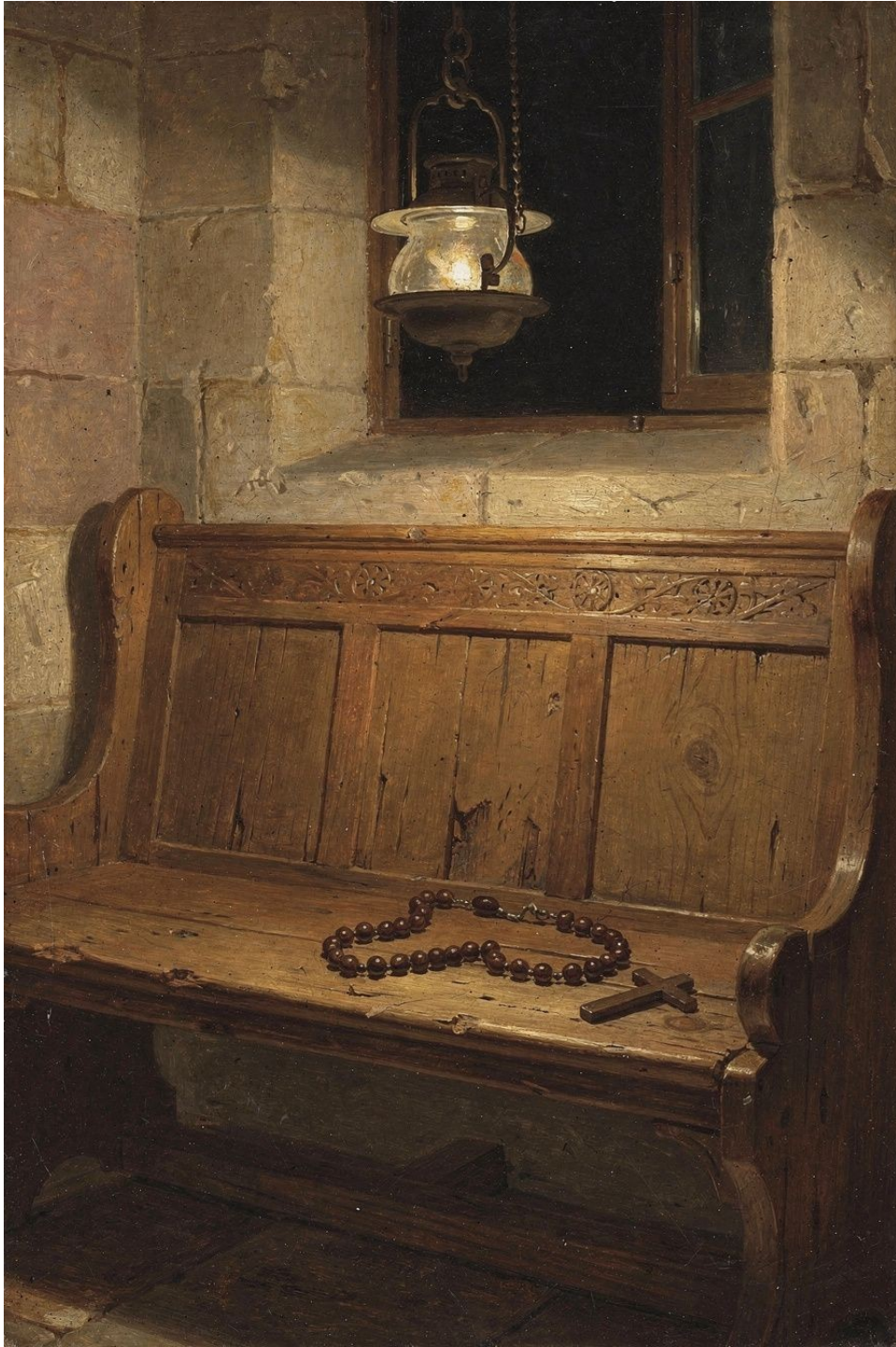


Illustration for Chapter 4

People think prayer always feels warm, like cocoa. Sometimes it does. Often it does not.

Thérèse taught that dry prayer still counts. Showing up matters more than collecting a nice feeling. A child can fall asleep in a father's boat and still be with the father. The child is not

"winning" prayer. The child is present. The chapel in Carmel was the same chapel every day. Some days the words of the psalms felt alive. Some days they felt like stones. She still went.

Later, after Good Friday 1896, when she first coughed blood, the dryness got huge. She did not tell everyone at once. She kept her duties as long as she could. For about eighteen months, until she died on September 30, 1897, she felt a night in her soul. She wrote that she was plunged into darkness. Everything disappeared, she said, and she was left with only love. God hid. She was tempted to think there was no heaven. She still chose to love.

This is hard. It is not a game. It is not "pretend you are sad." Thérèse did not stop believing on purpose. She lost the *feeling* of belief, and she still chose love. That is a grown-up idea. For this booklet, keep one piece: feelings are not the same as love, and feeling empty does not mean you failed.

A woman who later took Thérèse's name, Mother Teresa of Calcutta, also wrote about a long darkness while she still served poor people. The two stories are not the same life. They rhyme. Darkness can sit next to work. That does not make darkness a contest.

If a child feels sad for a long time, or scared in a heavy way, that is a time for a grown-up and, if needed, a doctor. Thérèse's dark night is not a homework assignment. It is part of her story.

Words to Remember

"If you only knew what darkness I am plunged into!"

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— Thérèse, in the time of her last illness (*Story of a Soul*, Manuscript C, and letters)

Plain English: She told the truth. She did not paste a smile over the dark.

"Everything has disappeared for me and I'm left with only love."

>

— Thérèse, same period

Plain English: When the warm feelings left, she held onto love as a choice.

Big Idea

Prayer is not a mood. Love can stay when the mood goes dark. Also: a long heavy sadness is a reason to tell a grown-up, not a reason to "try harder" alone.

Try This

1. Sit still for one minute with a grown-up nearby. No phone. No job. Just sit. Afterward, say whether it felt easy or boring. Both answers are allowed. 2. Light a candle (with a grown-up) and say one true sentence to God, even if the sentence is "I don't feel anything." 3. Draw a boat at night with no stars. Put a small sleeping shape in it. Title it "still with the Father."

Ask a Grown-Up

What do you do when you cannot feel God, or when you feel empty? Who do we tell if sadness lasts?

Chapter 5: The Offering She Did Not Invent



Illustration for Chapter 5

Thérèse got tuberculosis, a lung sickness that was common and deadly then. She did not choose the germ. She did choose what to do with the days she had. Fever. Cough. Hard breathing. She was afraid. She cried. She told her sisters she was suffering. She did not pretend to be a statue.

On June 9, 1895, during a community retreat, she wrote a prayer called the Act of Oblation to Merciful Love. This was before the worst of the illness. She offered herself not to a cold "you get what you deserve" picture of God, but to merciful love. Mercy is love that is bigger than what we earn. She had also taken a second part of her religious name: of the Holy Face. Child Jesus and the suffering face of Jesus. Sweetness and the hard look of pain. Same person.

She used strong old words: victim, holocaust, consume. Those words mean a gift completely given. They do not mean "sickness is a prize" or "don't take medicine." Thérèse was cared for in the infirmary. By July 1897 she was there more and more. The sisters attended her body. The offering was her yes inside a suffering that was already there.

This booklet will not tell a sick child that pain is a gift. Pain should be told to a grown-up. Doctors exist for a reason. Thérèse's teaching is narrower: if suffering is already in the room, love can still be offered. That is different from calling harm good. Nobody should stay in harm that can be stopped.

She also thought of other people: missionaries far away, people who did not know they were loved. Hidden prayer, she believed, could still be for the world. Her last words, the pack says, were "My God, I love you." Simple. Not a trick. A child telling the Father the last true sentence.

Words to Remember

"In order to live in one single act of perfect Love, I OFFER MYSELF AS A VICTIM OF HOLOCAUST TO YOUR MERCIFUL LOVE, asking You to consume me incessantly, letting the waves of infinite tenderness shut up within You flow out into my soul."

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— Thérèse, **Act of Oblation to Merciful Love**, June 9, 1895

Plain English: She asked to be filled with God's kindness, not to show off how tough she was.

Big Idea

Mercy is larger than a scoreboard. Suffering is not a toy and not a punishment-game. Love can be offered inside hard days. Harm that can be stopped should be stopped.

Try This

1. Make a card for someone who is sick or tired. Do not write "this is good for you." Write "I am with you." 2. With a grown-up, name one way your family helps a body that hurts: rest, medicine, a doctor, a quiet room. 3. Place a small empty bowl on a table. Call it "mercy." Put nothing in it. Let it be a picture of receiving, not earning.

Ask a Grown-Up

How do we help people who are sick without pretending that being sick is lucky?

Chapter 6: Love in the Heart of the Church



Illustration for Chapter 6

Thérèse read Saint Paul's letter about the Church as a body with many parts: speakers, teachers, people who go far away. She did not see herself as any of those famous parts. Then she read that the greatest is love.

She wrote: "In the heart of the Church, my Mother, I shall be Love."

A heart is hidden. If you take it out to show it off, it cannot do its job. Thérèse thought hidden love keeps the whole body alive.

She wrote letters to two missionary brothers she was given to pray for: Fr. Maurice Bellière, who was going toward Africa, and Fr. Adolphe Roulland, who was going toward China. She never walked their roads. She still wrote as if their work and her hidden work belonged together. Years later the Church named her co-patron of the missions with Francis Xavier, who had traveled far. The pairing sounds odd until you remember the heart and the feet.

After she died, her sisters Pauline and Céline gathered her writings into a book, *Story of a Soul*, published in 1898. It went around the world. People called her the Little Flower. In 1925 the Church named her a saint. In 1997 she was named a Doctor of the Church, a teacher. The girl who felt too small for the stairs became a teacher of the little way. Her parents, Louis and Zélie, were later named saints together as a married couple.

Her sisters edited the first book to make it smoother. Later scholars printed the original notebooks more plainly. Both facts can be true: the world met her through a book, and the book has a history.

She is not a doll. She is a person who asked a pope, smiled at a difficult sister, prayed when prayer was dry, and tried to be love in a hidden place.

Words to Remember

"In the heart of the Church, my Mother, I shall be Love."

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— Thérèse, **Story of a Soul**, Manuscript B

Plain English: Her job was not to be the loudest. Her job was to love, like a heart that stays at its work.

Big Idea

Hidden love is still real work. You do not have to be on a stage to belong to a body.

Try This

1. Do one helpful thing today that nobody claps for. Do not tell the table at dinner unless a grown-up asks. 2. Draw a body outline and put a heart in the middle. Label the heart "love" and the hands "work." Talk about both. 3. With a grown-up, look at a picture of a rose — only as a flower, not as a magic charm. Thérèse's later nickname used flowers. The real story is still the hidden heart.

Ask a Grown-Up

What hidden work in our family or church keeps things alive, the way a heart does?

For the Grown-Up Reader

This booklet follows Harry's Thérèse research pack (34 files, August 2026) and the ICS English *Story of a Soul* (John Clarke, OCD, 3rd ed., 1996) as the named edition. Quotes used here are ones the pack cites from Manuscripts A, B, and C, from the Act of Oblation (9 June 1895), and from the Rome audience with Leo XIII as Thérèse later narrated it.

Little-band edges: we do not assign children the dark night as a spiritual exercise. We do not say tuberculosis was a gift. We do not confuse dryness in prayer with clinical depression; a long heavy sadness is a reason to seek ordinary care. We do not treat "Little Flower" kitsch as the theology. We do not invent a shower-of-roses saying on the page. The sisters' early editing of *Histoire d'une Âme* is named without turning this into a courtroom. We do not tell an abused or bullied child that pain is holy. Harm that can be stopped should be stopped.

Did she really say these things? The elevator, the Little Way definition, the annoying-nun smile, the Act of Oblation, and "I shall be Love" are her texts as the pack cites them. The Pope's reply is from her own Rome account. Feeling-quotes from the last illness ("darkness I am plunged into," "left with only love") are from Manuscript C / late letters as the pack gives them. Last words ("My God, I love you") come from the illness file in the pack, not from a movie.

If a child asks whether she wanted to be sick: no. The disease arrived. She offered love inside it. That is a different sentence. If a child asks whether God hides on purpose to be mean: this booklet does not answer that as a puzzle. It says she told the truth about darkness and still loved.

No family names of the operator. No "safe for kids" claim. No medical or pastoral advice. This is a story booklet, not a clinic and not a homily substitute.

About WisdomForge

WisdomForge produces four age-adapted booklets for each figure: elementary (ages 5–10), middle (ages 11–14), high (ages 15–18), and adult. Each booklet covers the same person, ideas, and stories, but at a different level of depth and complexity. The elementary booklet tells stories. The middle booklet explains ideas. The high booklet argues and analyzes. The adult booklet engages with scholarly debates and primary sources. Read the one that fits — or read them all and watch the same figure grow.